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AMERICAN MARKETING ASSOCIATION

Article

Journal of Marketing Research
2026, Vol. 63(1) 191-209
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DOI: 10.1177/00222437251337723
journals.sagepub.com/home/mrj

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Just Keep It: When and Why Returnless Product Returns Foster Brand Support

John P. Costello and Christopher J. Bechler

Abstract

Many retailers now use "returnless returns," which allow customers to keep the products they want to return. Nine studies demonstrate that consumers who experience returnless returns demonstrate a greater likelihood to patronize the brand and are more likely to share positive word of mouth relative to consumers who are told to return these products (i.e., as in standard product returns) and consumers who make purchases that are not returned. This effect generalizes across contexts (e.g., reasons for initiating the return) and is mediated through brand warmth, as allowing consumers to keep unwanted purchases signals a communal orientation. Leveraging their theoretical framework, the authors identify moderators to offer insights into how managers considering offering returnless product returns can most effectively signal brand warmth and foster support. Specifically, returnless returns increase brand support when proof of product issue is not required, the decision is framed as specific to that consumer and situation, the brand provides a consumer- or environmentally-centric motive for the decision, and the brand suggests donating the kept product. Thus, the findings identify an often-overlooked benefit of returnless returns beyond cutting costs and provide managers with practical guidance about how to communicate with consumers during returnless return experiences to foster future brand support.

Keywords

product returns, postpurchase consumer behavior, brand support, warmth, consumer–brand relationships

Online supplement: https://doi.org/10.1177/00222437251337723

Submitted May 10, 2024

Consumers today return one out of every five online purchases (Repko 2022). This presents a serious challenge because the revenues generated from reselling or refurbishing a returned product often do not cover the additional costs (e.g., transportation, warehousing, customer service) associated with processing the return (Kavilanz 2022). In response, many leading retailers no longer require that customers send a recently purchased and unwanted product back to them—instead, they simply tell customers to "just keep it." This strategy, which we refer to as "returnless product returns" or "returnless returns," has become a common practice across a variety of product categories and price points (Baertlein and McLymore 2023), with some firms (e.g., Bombas, Chewy) instituting blanket returnless policies across all situations and customers, and others (e.g., Amazon, Lowe's, Walmart) implementing them widely on a case-by-case basis. As evidence of the practice's rapid growth and increasing prevalence, a 2023 survey of over 500 retail executives found that 59% of respondents used returnless returns compared with just 26% in the prior year (Baertlein and McLymore 2023).

However, despite the attention paid to this product return strategy in the popular press (e.g., Cerullo 2021; Reuter 2024) and the strategy's increasing prevalence in practice, returnless returns have received no attention in top marketing journals.[1] The current narrative in much of the popular press as to why companies are increasingly using returnless returns focuses on their potential to manage costs (e.g., to minimize losses in profits due to processing costs; Cerullo 2021; Kavilanz 2022; Repko 2022; Reuter 2024). Consistent with this perspective, a pilot study we conducted with 200 retail professionals with an average of 17 years of professional experience ($M_{age} = 37.5$ years; 56.5% female, 39.5% male, 4.0% other) found that the vast majority

[1] In fact, as of February 16, 2025, zero articles in *Journal of Marketing Research* or five other top journals in the field that appear on the *Financial Times* 50 list (*Journal of Consumer Psychology*, *Journal of Consumer Research*, *Journal of Marketing*, *Marketing Science*, and *Journal of the Academy of Marketing Science*) include the terms "returnless product return," "returnless return," "returnless policy," "returnless refund," or "returnless replacement."

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(80.5%) viewed returnless returns primarily as a strategy to minimize costs rather than to generate future support for the brand (see Web Appendix A for additional details).

While we acknowledge the importance of returnless returns in managing costs associated with product returns, the present article adds a new perspective to this discussion by spotlighting the potential and often neglected benefits of this strategy in driving outcomes that impact top-line growth. We find that when consumers wish to send back unwanted products, using returnless returns increases brand support (e.g., repurchase likelihood, positive word of mouth [WOM]) relative to carrying out standard product returns. Further, the brand support generated via returnless returns can be greater than the support generated when a consumer does not initiate a return (i.e., they do not need to send back the item). Our evidence suggests that boosts in brand support arising from returnless returns are driven by increased perceptions of brand warmth.

Our research contributes to existing literature on product returns (Bower and Maxham 2012; Petersen and Kumar 2009; Wood 2001), consumer–brand relationships (Aggarwal 2009; Aggarwal and Law 2005), and warmth perceptions in marketing (Aaker, Vohs, and Mogilner 2010; Fournier and Alvarez 2012; Gershon and Cryder 2018; Kervyn, Fiske, and Malone 2012; Philipp-Muller, Costello, and Reczek 2023) and integrates these three topics, demonstrating how new types of product returns can influence brand warmth perceptions and, ultimately, consumers' support of the brand. As the first article to explore returnless returns, our research contributes to the literature on postpurchase behavior more broadly (e.g., Cakanlar, Nikolova, and Nenkov 2023; Dommer and Winterich 2021; Koukova, Wang, and Isaac 2023; Winterich, Nenkov, and Gonzales 2019) and answers calls for more research testing the role of product return policies on brand support (Robertson, Hamilton, and Jap 2020).

In addition to documenting the effect of returnless returns on brand support and the underlying mechanism explaining it, we leverage our new theoretical framework to identify several managerially relevant variables that impact the extent to which returnless returns increase brand warmth and, thus, support. In doing so, we provide practical guidance for how managers and brands should design product return procedures and communicate with consumers when they no longer want their recent purchases. Namely, we find that returnless returns more effectively increase brand support when they do not require that the customer supply proof (e.g., a photograph of the product), when the decision is framed as specific to that consumer and situation (vs. a blanket policy), when the brand provides a consumer- or environmentally-centric motive for the decision (vs. a company-centric motive), and when the brand suggests that the customer donate the kept product (vs. no suggestion or suggests disposal).

Theoretical Background

Product Returns

Product returns describe previously purchased products that consumers choose to exchange for a refund (for the original payment or store credit) or a replacement product (e.g., Abdulla, Ketzenberg, and Abbey 2019). Product returns have often been viewed as a cost center or a "necessary evil" (Petersen and Kumar 2009) that mainly serves as a source of frustration for managers. The challenges associated with product returns have skyrocketed in recent years—for example, data from the National Retail Federation shows that return rates have nearly doubled from prepandemic levels (Baertlein and McLymore 2023). Thus, decisions around product returns are more impactful than ever. The topic of product returns is not a new one in the academic literature; however, much of the research to date has focused on operational issues (Abdulla, Ketzenberg, and Abbey 2019). Indeed, even though "consumer behavior plays a significant role in setting policy and developing consumer insights," a systematic analysis of decades' worth of research exploring product returns in operations, marketing, and economics concluded that, as compared with other areas, "relatively little is empirically established regarding consumer behavior in relation to return policies" (Abdulla, Ketzenberg, and Abbey 2019, p. 561).

Our research aims to help fill this gap and add to the small but growing literature that acknowledges product returns as a marketing tool that can influence consumers' behavior. Prior research studying consumer behavior and psychology around returns has shed light on a variety of important issues, including consumer response to return fees (Bower and Maxham 2012), how prechoice cognitions impact the likelihood of return (Bechwati and Siegal 2005), the impact of return policy leniency on deliberation and search (Wood 2001), and how consumers spend their refunds in different ways than nonrefunded money (Yu, Cryder, and LeBoeuf 2023). We seek to further this literature by exploring consumer response to returnless returns, focusing our investigation on how carrying out this strategy impacts consumers' perceptions of the brand. Research on consumer–brand relationships conducted over several decades has found that people perceive brands much like they perceive other people (Kervyn, Fiske, and Malone 2012, 2022) and that these perceptions influence the extent to which consumers support the brand (Kervyn, Fiske, and Malone 2012). In line with this research, we propose that returnless returns can influence brand support through changes in perceptions of the brand implementing the strategy.

The Impact of Returnless Product Returns on Brand Warmth and Support

One of the most popular psychological frameworks for understanding the social perception of other people and groups is the stereotype content model (Fiske, Cuddy, and Glick 2007). This model posits that people form interpersonal assessments of social others along two fundamental dimensions: warmth and competence. Warmth relates to the anticipation of other's intentions toward them—that is, the extent to which a perceiver views the other entity as friendly, generous, sincere, and having the perceiver's best interest at heart. In contrast, competence relates to perceptions about the extent to which the entity can execute its intentions (e.g., how effective and efficient it is).

Research in marketing has found that impressions of warmth and competence are central not only to perceptions of people (e.g., service employees; Li, Chan, and Kim 2019) but also in evaluations of nonhuman entities like product development processes (Philipp-Muller, Costello, and Reczek 2023), money (Zhou, Kim, and Wang 2019), and organizations (Aaker, Vohs, and Mogilner 2010; Gershon and Cryder 2018; Lee, Bolton, and Winterich 2017). While both warmth and competence are considered fundamental in social perception, there is growing evidence for a "primacy of warmth" (Kervyn, Fiske, and Malone 2022; Wojciszke, Bazinska, and Jaworski 1998), where evaluators weight warmth more heavily than competence when forming an evaluation of an entity. Consistent with this, recent work finds that brand warmth is more impactful than competence in driving behavioral outcomes (Kolbl et al. 2020).

We suggest that a brand implementing returnless returns increases the degree to which consumers perceive the brand as warm because returnless returns impact how consumers view their relationship with the brand. Research on consumer–brand relationships often defines relationships as either communal or exchange-based (Aggarwal 2009; Aggarwal and Law 2005; Heyman and Ariely 2004). Exchange-based relationships are based on reciprocity, where something is given only after something equivalent is received. In contrast, communal relationships are based more on mutual support and take a perspective that transcends self-interest alone (Aggarwal 2009).

Previous work has argued that a typical baseline relationship between a consumer and a brand is primarily commercial and exchange-based (Aggarwal 2009). However, we predict that telling a consumer to "just keep it" with no expectation of anything in return causes consumers to view their relationship with the brand as more communal than baseline, as providing some benefit without expectation of reciprocation is a defining feature of communal relationships (Clark and Mils 1993). Returnless returns may also promote a communal relationship because they can serve as an implied signal about what the company thinks of the consumer as a person (Summers, Smith, and Reczek 2016). Specifically, amid ongoing and growing concerns around product return fraud (Baertlein and McLymore 2023), offering a returnless product return signals that a brand views the consumer as trustworthy and not engaging in fraudulent behavior. This inference should promote a communal relationship with the brand, as a sense of mutual trust in a relationship partner is key to fostering a more communal orientation (Miller et al. 2014).

Because entities that engage in communal acts are perceived as warmer (Zahry and Besley 2021)—a link that is especially strong when the communal act involves providing goods versus other resources (e.g., money; Gershon and Cryder 2018)—the communal action of allowing a consumer to keep an unwanted product should boost consumers' perceptions of the brand's warmth. We expect that because returnless returns increase perceptions of warmth, this warmth in turn will increase consumers' likelihood to patronize and recommend the brand (Kervyn, Fiske, and Malone 2012; Kim, Murray, and Moore 2023; Mende et al. 2020). Formally:

H_1: Using returnless returns increases consumers' likelihood to patronize and recommend the brand relative to (a) when products do not need to be returned (i.e., a control condition) and (b) using standard product returns.

H_2: The effect predicted in H_1 is serially mediated by perceptions of an increased (a) communal orientation of the brand and (b) brand warmth.

When Will Returnless Product Returns Be Most Effective?

Amazon popularized returnless returns when it introduced this option in 2019 (Sharma 2019). In the years since, a growing number of firms have followed Amazon's lead, such as Chewy, Keurig, True Classic, and Wayfair (Baertlein and McLymore 2023; see Web Appendix B for examples of real brands that use returnless returns). However, given the newness of the phenomenon, it is pivotal that research on this topic build a greater understanding of when and how implementing returnless product returns will be most effective. With this goal in mind, we leverage our theoretical framework to identify practically useful moderators aimed at providing insights that brands can use when designing their product return strategies.

The first factor we explore is whether the brand requires proof of a product issue when offering a returnless return. Although providing proof is not the norm for most brands that offer returnless returns, examples of such approaches exist in the marketplace. For example, Petco offers returnless returns for certain categories (e.g., fish or plants that die within seven days of delivery) but requires a "photograph of your specimen as proof of loss." We suspect that this type of requirement makes it less likely for consumers to view the brand as acting based on mutual trust and kindness expected in communal relationships. Based on this, we anticipate that requiring proof (e.g., a photograph of the defective or incorrect item) will attenuate the positive effects we predict in H_1 and H_2. Formally:

H_3: The effects predicted in H_1 and H_2 are mitigated when the brand requires proof of a product issue in exchange for offering a returnless return.

The next set of factors we explore involves how the brand designs its returnless product return policy and communicates its decision-making process around product returns to consumers. Specifically, we test how the boost in brand support can differ depending on whether the brand designs the returnless product return policy to be implemented on a case-by-case basis versus as a blanket policy (H_4), communicates consumer- or environmentally-centric motives versus company-centric motives as the reason for using returnless returns (H_5), and suggests product disposition methods that vary in warmth (e.g., donation = warm; H_6).

First, returnless product return policies can vary in their design and how this design is communicated to customers (see Web Appendix B). Some brands seemingly implement a blanket returnless policy for all customers and situations (e.g., Chewy, Bombas). In contrast, others employ returnless policies on a case-by-case basis (e.g., Amazon, Walmart). On the one hand, blanket returnless policies might boost brand support more than their case-by-case counterparts because making explicit that a returnless policy is being used selectively could cause consumers to expect that this returnless option will not be available to them in the future when they want to return an item. However, drawing from our theorizing that offering returnless product returns boosts brand support because they increase brand warmth, we predict that returnless policies implemented on a case-by-case basis are more effective.

Offering returnless product returns on a case-by-case basis might further boost brand warmth in two ways. First, we expect that consumers will view being selected as a case-specific beneficiary of returnless product return policies as "special treatment" (Feinberg, Krishna, and John Zhang 2002). Prior research shows that when consumers uniquely receive special treatment or benefits (i.e., the treatment is not offered to many others), consumers view their relationship with the brand as more communal and warmer (Henderson, Beck, and Palmatier 2011). Second, communicating to consumers that they are being selected as case-specific beneficiaries of returnless product return policies also implies that rather than an automatic email being sent, a human is reviewing their case and intervening in the return process. This additional level of human intervention should also benefit the brand's warmth perceptions, as warmth is viewed as a fundamental quality of humans (Gray and Wegner 2012), and increasing the level of "humanness" in digital interactions has been shown to increase perceptions of warmth (Kim, Schmitt, and Thalmann 2019).

We therefore expect that when a brand representative offers a returnless return in response to a consumer's specific situation, it reinforces the communality of the relationship and further boosts the brand's perceived warmth, leading to greater brand support. In other words, while we expect that returnless returns will lead to positive effects versus standard returns for both blanket and case-by-case decisions, we expect that the effects will be particularly pronounced when made on a case-by-case basis. Formally:

> **H_4:** The positive effect of offering returnless product returns on brand support is stronger when the brand communicates that the decision was made on a case-by-case basis rather than as part of a blanket policy.

Second, we suspect that the benefits of returnless product returns on brand support can vary depending on how the motivation for implementing them is communicated. As mentioned previously, cost reduction is the primary and most discussed motivator for implementing returnless returns (Baertlein and McLymore 2023). We label this motivator a "company-centric motive" because concerns related to the firm's costs and profitability drive the strategy's implementation. However, implementing returnless returns can also benefit consumers directly by removing the hassle associated with returning an item, and a brand could instead frame its motivation for implementing the strategy as making a consumer's life easier in this way (i.e., communicate a "consumer-centric motive"). This type of kindness and generosity is characteristic of warm brands (Aaker, Vohs, and Mogilner 2010; Kervyn, Fiske, and Malone 2012). Brands may also offer returnless returns to minimize negative environmental impact by reducing waste and carbon emissions (Cerullo 2021). We expect this type of "environmentally-centric motive" will signal warmth as more sustainable brands are typically viewed as warmer (Antonetti and Maklan 2016; Septianto, Seo, and Zhao 2022). Thus, we expect that a company-centric approach will decrease brand warmth and, thus, brand support, whereas a consumer-centric or environmentally-centric approach will increase brand warmth and support. Formally:

> **H_5:** The positive effect of offering returnless product returns on brand support is stronger when the brand communicates that the decision was made for consumer-centric or environmentally-centric motives than for company-centric motives.

Third, brands implementing returnless product returns must decide whether to make suggestions about what consumers should do with the nonreturned product and, if they choose to do so, what they should recommend. We suspect that many firms introducing returnless returns might overlook these questions because, as mentioned previously, companies and managers tend to focus on costs when implementing this strategy, and the costs to the firm remain the same regardless of whether the firm makes a recommendation. This could be why, in current practice, some firms (e.g., Chewy) make suggestions about what consumers should do with the nonreturned product, whereas others may not (e.g., Goodr).

When consumers want to return a product, but the brand directs them to "just keep it," they must decide what to do with an item they do not want or need. On the one hand, research on psychological reactance suggests that making unsolicited recommendations about what consumers should do with this original product could decrease support because consumers like having control and dislike being directed on what to do (Clee and Wicklund 1980). On the other hand, communicating a suggestion about what to do with the kept product offers the brand an additional opportunity to signal warmth, which could further boost brand support. Prior donations research shows a link between giving behaviors and warmth perceptions (Gershon and Cryder 2018; Kervyn, Fiske, and Malone 2022); thus, using our theoretical framework as a guide, we propose that suggesting that consumers donate the kept item will be particularly effective in bolstering perceptions of brand warmth and thus support. However, disposal suggestions not associated with giving (e.g., broadly suggesting disposition) should not boost warmth and, thus, support.

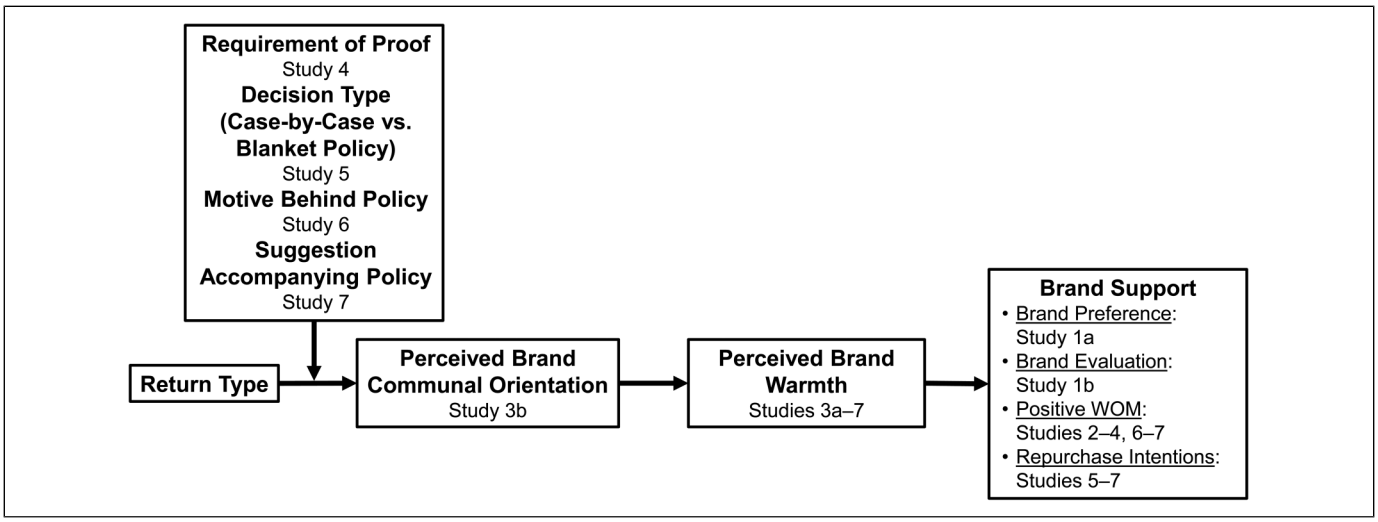


Figure 1. Conceptual Framework.

H_6: The positive effect of offering returnless product returns on brand support is stronger when the brand suggests donating the kept item than when (a) no suggestion is made or (b) a nondonation disposal suggestion is made.

Study Overview

Across nine main studies (see Figure 1 and Table 1), we find that offering returnless product returns increases brand support. This effect is robust to a variety of product types (e.g., pens, phone chargers, diarrheal medication, T-shirts, sweaters, food), whether the company provides a refund or replacement, and across a variety of motives for making a return (e.g., when the product is not as expected, when the consumer orders a product then receives the same product as a gift, when the product is defective). We first test H_1 in ecologically valid contexts in Studies 1a and 1b, where research assistants pose as brand ambassadors for real brands and provide a product that needs to be returned. Study 1a tests H_{1a} by comparing returnless returns with a control condition where no return occurs, and Study 1b tests H_{1b} by using a standard return as the comparison condition. Study 2 builds on these studies by including both a control and a standard return condition, using sentiment analysis of textual reviews to show that the positive effect of returnless returns emerges when the brand is not at fault for the return. Studies 3a and 3b test both H_1 and H_2, demonstrating the mediating role of perceived brand warmth and ruling out additional mechanisms. Importantly, Study 3b tests the full serial model, demonstrating that returnless returns promote a more communal orientation, which drives warmth and brand support.

The remaining studies leverage our theoretical framework to identify when returnless returns are most effective and offer practical insights into how these product return policies should be designed and communicated. Study 4 tests H_3, demonstrating that the positive effects of returnless returns are mitigated when the brand requires proof of a product issue when a returnless return is offered. Study 5 shows that the positive effect of returnless returns is particularly strong when it is determined on a case-by-case (vs. blanket policy) basis (H_4), Study 6 shows that the positive effects of returnless returns on brand support are stronger when the brand communicates that the decision was made for consumer-centric or environmentally-centric (vs. company-centric) motives (H_5), and Study 7 shows that the positive effect of offering returnless returns on brand support is stronger when the brand suggests donating the nonreturned item (H_6). In each case, these effects are mediated by perceived brand warmth. All manipulations, conditions, measures, and data exclusions for these studies are reported in the main text and are available in Web Appendix C. When we had control over sample size (e.g., for online studies), sample sizes were determined prior to data collection, with 100 participants or more per condition. In cases where we had less control over sample size (e.g., for in-person studies), we collected data over a predetermined number of days and times, aiming for 50 participants or more per condition. In all cases, all completed responses are included in our analyses. The data for all studies are available at https://osf.io/2jrxq/.

Study 1a: Returnless Returns (vs. No Return Necessary) Increase Brand Preference

The purpose of Study 1a was to test whether returnless returns can boost brand support (specifically, brand preference) over and above situations when consumers receive products they do not need to return (H_{1a}). Participants experienced an ecologically valid situation where research assistants posed as brand ambassadors conducting market research for a real brand.

Method

A total of 105 students ($M_{age} = 19.2$ years; 51.4% female, 48.6% male) participated in the study, which took place in a

Table 1. Overview of Studies.

Study (Key Test)	Dependent Measure	No Return	Standard Returns	Returnless Returns
1a (H_{1a})	Brand preference	4.19_a	—	5.00_b
1b (H_{1b})	Brand evaluation	—	3.57_a	4.45_b
2 (H_{1a} and H_{1b})	Positive sentiment (LIWC)	6.14_a	6.34_a	7.99_b
3a (H_2)	Positive WOM	5.29_a	5.23_a	5.91_b
	Warmth	4.52_a	5.25_b	5.91_c
	Competence	5.81_a	5.92_a	5.80_a
	Value	4.14_a	5.63_b	5.38_b
3b (H_2)	Positive WOM	—	3.04_a	4.22_b
	Warmth	—	3.55_a	4.63_b
	Communal orientation	—	3.85_a	4.71_b
	Morality	—	4.10_a	4.58_a
	Coolness	—	3.59_a	4.09_b
	Novelty	—	3.69_a	3.88_a
4 (H_3)	Positive WOM	—	3.48_a	No proof: 4.35_b Proof required: 3.57_a
	Warmth	—	3.77_a	No proof: 4.85_b Proof required: 3.92_a
5 (H_4)	Repurchase intentions	—	Policy: 3.00_a Case-by-case: 2.81_a	Policy: 4.93_b Case-by-case: 5.63_c
	Warmth	—	Policy: 2.89_a Case-by-case: 2.59_a	Policy: 4.83_b Case-by-case: 5.28_c
6 (H_5)	Positive WOM	—	3.20_a	Consumer-centric: 5.31_b Environmentally-centric: 5.11_b Company-centric: 4.69_c
	Repurchase intentions	—	3.44_a	Consumer-centric: 5.48_b Environmentally-centric: 5.30_b Company-centric: 4.82_c
	Warmth	—	3.51_a	Consumer-centric: 5.78_b Environmentally-centric: 5.46_c Company-centric: 4.59_d
7 (H_6)	Positive WOM	—	—	No suggestion: 5.59_a Suggest donation: 5.93_b Suggest disposal: 5.24_c
	Repurchase intentions	—	—	No suggestion: 5.60_a Suggest donation: 5.87_b Suggest disposal: 5.20_c
	Warmth	—	—	No suggestion: 5.67_a Suggest donation: 5.97_b Suggest disposal: 5.37_c

Notes: Subscripts should be interpreted within the dependent variable (i.e., row) only. Values with the same subscript do not differ from each other at a $p < .05$ level.

behavioral lab on a university campus in the United States. All participants were informed that they were completing a market research survey for BIC pens. They further learned that the purpose of the survey was to understand the needs of students because college students are an important market for pen companies. Consistent with the study's stated purpose, participants were shown a series of pens and asked questions assessing their opinions of the pens (e.g., "If you could change one thing about these pens, what would it be?"), their valuations of the pens (e.g., "What do you think a fair price would be for these pens"), and their purchase likelihood (e.g., "How likely would you be to purchase these pens?"; Web Appendix C). After completing this market research survey, participants were informed that as part of their compensation, they could choose to receive either a blue or black BIC pen.

At this point, the research assistant escorted participants one at a time to one of two rooms (which varied by random assignment) to receive the BIC pen they chose and complete a short paper survey. Participants assigned to the control condition (i.e., assigned to receive a product they did not need to return) were escorted to a room with two colors of pens (blue and black), a stack of paper surveys, a ballot box on a table, and a research assistant posing as a campus brand ambassador for BIC who sat behind the table. The research assistant told the participants to take the color pen they chose, complete the paper survey with that pen, fold it up, and place it in the ballot box. The ballot box was opaque, so no participants or research assistants could see the previously completed surveys inside the box. The paper survey consisted of a single question that was the dependent measure of interest in the study: "Compared to

other competitors, how much do you like BIC?" (1 = "I like BIC much less than its competitors," 4 = "I like BIC about the same as its competitors," and 7 = "I like BIC much more than its competitors").

Participants assigned to the returnless return condition were escorted to a different room with an identical setup. However, in this room, the brand ambassador provided participants with the color pen they selected during the first part of the study and told them to complete the paper survey with the pen. Although the pen that participants received appeared normal at first glance, participants realized upon attempting to complete the paper survey that the pen was missing ink (we removed the internal ink cartridge before the study). When participants alerted the brand ambassador to the issue, the brand ambassador handed the participant a working pen (i.e., a pen with ink) in the color they chose and told the participant that they could keep the defective pen without ink in it, as it was BIC's policy that customers do not need to return items they need to replace. As in the control condition, participants in the returnless condition folded up their completed surveys and placed them in the opaque ballot box to keep their responses confidential.

We purposefully chose the stimulus in this study (a defective pen without ink) so that participants in the returnless condition would perceive little to no value in the item they originally received. A pretest conducted on the same participant population (n = 101) confirmed that this was the case. A total of 100 out of 101 participants (99.0%) stated that this defective pen had no financial value. This conclusion was replicated on a continuous scale—when rating the value of the pen on (a scale from 1 = "not valuable at all" to 7 = "extremely valuable"), the average response was 1.24 (SD = .63). While just 5.9% of participants said they would keep the defective pen if they received it, 94.1% said they would either throw it away or recycle it (see Web Appendix A for more details on this pretest).

Results and Discussion

To test our first key hypothesis (H_{1a}) that implementing returnless returns can boost brand support over and above that when consumers receive products that they do not need to return, we analyzed the effect of experiencing a returnless return on preference for BIC pens via an ANOVA. As predicted, participants who experienced a returnless return ($M = 5.00$, $SD = 1.13$) preferred BIC significantly more than participants who received a pen that they did not need to return ($M = 4.19$, $SD = 1.27$; $F(1, 103) = 11.91$, $p < .001$, $\eta^2 = .10$). This study provides initial evidence in an ecologically valid context that returnless returns can boost brand support after consumers experience real mistakes. The current study builds on and extends prior work that shows how various service recovery strategies may be used to mitigate potential damage after a firm failure (Dewitt and Brady 2003); the boost to support the brand after returnless returns can even occur relative to a situation when things go right and the participant receives the desired item.

Study 1b: Returnless Returns (vs. Standard Returns) Increase Brand Evaluation

Study 1b tested H_{1b} in a field setting, assessing whether a new brand's use of returnless returns increases brand support (specifically, evaluation) relative to standard returns.

Method

A total of 102 people[2] ($M_{age} = 20.1$ years; 66.7% female, 27.5% male; 5.9% no response) on a university campus in the United States completed Study 1b. Passersby were recruited by a research assistant who wore a nametag indicating they were a campus brand ambassador for an ostensibly real online-ordering snack startup called Mazo Delivery. Participants scanned a QR code using their phone to begin the study, which required them to choose between two snacks (Skittles or Reese's, which were Americans' two most popular Halloween candies; Easington 2021) and complete demographic information, including age and gender. After the participant completed these questions, the Mazo Delivery brand ambassador pretended to look up the participant's order in the Mazo Delivery system on their phone. After 10–15 seconds, the brand ambassador looked up from their phone and told each participant, "Based on the most recent entry in the ordering system that I'm seeing here, you selected the candy corn" and handed candy corn to the participant. We chose candy corn because it is often viewed as a low-value item (it was rated as Americans' least favorite Halloween candy in a national survey; Rosenthal 2019), particularly when compared with the two candies that participants chose between.

When participants objected to receiving the incorrect snack,[3] the brand ambassador implemented the focal manipulation. Participants assigned to the returnless return condition were told they could keep the original item (candy corn). In contrast, those in the standard return condition were asked to give the item back. After participants chose the correct snack from the bag, they scanned a new QR code that directed them to rate their experience with Mazo Delivery on a smiley face scale (1 = "☹," and 5 = "☺"; Web Appendix C).

Results and Discussion

To test our hypothesis (H_{1b}) that implementing returnless returns can increase brand support relative to standard returns,

[2] Data collection for this study occurred over two months, with multiple research assistants collecting data. This meant that it was possible for participants to take the study more than once (e.g., if different research assistants approached them on two different days). However, since participants used their personal devices to take the survey, we can identify these duplicate responses using the IP addresses recorded in Qualtrics. Therefore, in our primary analysis, we removed responses from duplicate IP addresses (five responses) to address this concern. The inclusion of these responses (n = 107) does not change the significance of our results ($p < .001$).

[3] Only participants who mentioned to the research assistants that they received the incorrect snack were assigned to an experimental condition, received the manipulation, and completed the follow-up survey.

we analyzed the effect of the return policy on participants' experiences with Mazo Delivery via an ANOVA. As predicted, participants who experienced a returnless return reported significantly better evaluations of their brand experience ($M = 4.45$, $SD = .79$) than those who experienced a standard return ($M = 3.57$, $SD = 1.30$; $F(1, 100) = 17.66$, $p < .001$, $\eta^2 = .15$).

Studies 1a–b provide field and lab evidence support for H_1 in situations where consumers believed they were interacting with ambassadors for real brands. One limitation of these studies is that they explore situations in which the firm's mistake (providing a defective or incorrect product) motivates the return. The real-world nature of Studies 1a–b required such an approach, since we needed participants to initiate a return. In Study 2, we assess whether the positive effect of returnless returns on brand support generalizes to situations where the brand's actions do not create the need for a return.

Study 2: Returnless Returns Boost Positive WOM When the Brand Is Not at Fault

Study 2 (preregistration: https://aspredicted.org/39L_L5K) had two primary purposes. First, we aimed to replicate H_1 using a new context (when the reason for the return is not the brand's fault) and a new measure of brand support (positive WOM). Second, we aimed to bridge the first two studies by comparing the effect of a returnless return with a standard product return and a situation in which the product does not need to be returned.

Method

A total of 600 Prolific workers ($M_{age} = 39.6$ years; 48.3% female, 49.5% male, 2.2% other) located in the United States participated in the study and were randomly assigned to one of three between-subjects conditions (returnless return vs. standard return vs. control). Participants in all conditions imagined that they purchased a shirt and were provided with some basic details about the shirt and purchase process (e.g., the shirt was short-sleeve and a cotton-polyester blend, cost $35, arrived in five business days; Web Appendix C). In the control condition, participants read that they decided to keep the shirt. In the standard return condition and returnless return condition, participants instead were told that they received the exact same shirt that they ordered later that day as a gift from a friend. In both of these latter two conditions, participants read that they contacted the brand to let them know about the situation because they did not need two of the same shirt. In the standard return condition, the brand directed the consumer to put the item in its original packaging so that they could pick up the item from their door to receive a refund. In the returnless return condition, the brand informed the consumer that there was no need to return the item in question for a refund and that the consumer could do whatever they wanted with it.

In all three conditions, participants wrote a review based on their interaction with the brand as they would on a real review website like Yelp or Amazon. Our primary interest (as preregistered) was the positive sentiment in the text of the written review as assessed via Linguistic Inquiry and Word Count (LIWC), the gold standard for assessing word usage in written text (Boyd et al. 2022). Positive sentiment is reflected by the software's tone_pos measure, which captures the use of words conveying positive emotions (e.g., happy, joy) as well as words related to these emotions (e.g., good) in text. Higher scores on this measure reflect more positive sentiment of the text (see also Kane and Van Swol 2023).

Results

We analyzed the effect of the condition on positive sentiment (measured via LIWC) via an omnibus ANOVA. As predicted, this analysis revealed that participants wrote reviews that differed in positive sentiment ($F(2, 597) = 6.20$, $p = .002$, $\eta^2 = .02$). Specifically, follow-up planned contrasts revealed that participants wrote reviews of the brand that were significantly more positive in the returnless return condition ($M = 7.99$, $SD = 6.40$) than in the control condition where no return was initiated ($M = 6.14$, $SD = 5.13$; $t(597) = 3.19$, $p = .002$, $d = .32$), supporting H_{1a}. Supporting H_{1b}, reviews of the brand were also significantly more positive in the returnless return condition than the standard return condition ($M = 6.34$, $SD = 5.77$; $t(597) = 2.87$, $p = .004$, $d = .27$).[4] Although we did not have an a priori hypothesis about differences between the control and standard return conditions, we found that the reviews in these conditions were not significantly different in terms of positivity ($t(597) = .35$, $p = .727$, $d = .04$).

Discussion

Study 2 shows further support for H_1 even when the reason for returning is not the fault of the brand. In addition, Study 2 captures how returnless returns boost brand support using a new measure of brand support: positive sentiment of a written review. Notably, however, Study 2 and prior studies do not precisely speak to the mechanism that explains why returnless returns boost brand support. In Studies 3a–b, we measure our hypothesized mechanism (perceived brand warmth) and possible alternatives.

Studies 3a and 3b: Testing Mechanism and Ruling Out Alternatives

Studies 3a and 3b were designed to provide an initial test of H_2—that the boost in brand support (specifically, positive

[4] While we did not measure warmth in this study, one potential proxy variable for warmth that is generated by LIWC is prosocial behavior. As an exploratory analysis and initial test of our proposed mechanism, we tested whether prosocial behavior mediated the observed differences in brand support via PROCESS (Mediation Model 4; multicategorical independent variable coded as returnless = 0, control = 1, standard return = 2; Hayes 2018). This analysis revealed two significant indirect effects (returnless vs. control: 95% CI = [−2.29, −.83]; returnless vs. standard: 95% CI = [−.95, −.03]), thus providing some initial evidence that perceived brand warmth significantly drives the effect of returnless returns on brand support. We thank an anonymous reviewer for this suggestion.

WOM) arising from using returnless returns is mediated by perceptions of brand warmth. In Study 3a, we also directly assess the feasibility of two alternative mechanisms that could additionally or better explain why returnless returns generate greater brand support. First, brands using returnless returns may appear more competent to consumers, as consumers might infer that the brand can use this strategy because it does not have to process returns often and/or has an excess of resources. Second, though we try to control for value in our studies (e.g., providing a pen with no ink in Study 1a), it may be possible that the boost in support is driven by greater perceived financial value from the transaction.

In Study 3b, we test the entire theorized serial model—specifically, whether the greater perceived warmth arising from using returnless returns is driven by increased perceptions of the communal orientation of the firm. This study also assesses the viability of three more potential alternatives: (1) perceived brand morality, (2) perceived brand coolness, and (3) perceived novelty of the experience. Study 3b also uses a valueless item as the kept product (like Study 1a) and explores whether the positive effects of returnless returns on positive WOM generalize to embarrassing products (an empty bottle of antidiarrheal medication). In both studies, we test all alternative mechanisms alongside our proposed process through parallel mediation analysis.

Study 3a: Method

A total of 302 individuals ($M_{age} = 43.8$ years; 49.7% female, 48.7% male, 1.3% other, .3% not reported) located in the United States were recruited from Amazon's Mechanical Turk using CloudResearch to participate in Study 3a. All participants imagined that they purchased a sweater from an online retailer. In all conditions, participants read that upon receiving the sweater, they judged it to be of decent quality and thought it looked like it did online. However, in the standard return and returnless return conditions, participants were also told that after trying it on, they determined that it did not look flattering on them. To further mitigate perceptions of the sweater's value, we also added that "the sweater is not the right size for any of your family or friends and you don't have any use for it." Mirroring Study 2, participants in these conditions were told that they contacted the brand about the situation and that the brand responded to let them know that the refund process was initiated. Depending on the condition, they were either asked to return the product by putting it in its original packaging and leaving it at their door for pickup (standard return) or informed that they did not need to return the item (returnless return).

After reading the brand's response, participants indicated their intentions to spread positive WOM about the brand through three statements (1= "Strongly disagree," and 7 = "Strongly agree"; $\alpha = .96$) taken from extant literature ("I would recommend this brand to someone who seeks my advice," "I would say positive things about this brand to other people," and "I would recommend this brand to others"; Smith, Vandellen, and Ton 2021). Participants also responded to items adapted from Aaker, Vohs, and Mogilner (2010) to assess perceived warmth ("To what extent do you think this seller is warm/kind/generous?"; $\alpha = .95$) and competence ("To what extent do you think this seller is competent/effective/efficient?"; $\alpha = .94$). Our item assessing perceived value was adapted from Salerno and Sevilla (2019): "How financially valuable to you is [this sweater/the refund for this unflattering sweater/the combination of the refund and this unflattering sweater]?" (1 = "Not at all valuable," and 7 = "Very valuable").

Study 3a: Results

Positive WOM. We first submitted our positive WOM measure to a one-way omnibus ANOVA with condition as the independent variable. Participants differed in their intentions to spread positive WOM based on condition ($F(2, 299) = 8.44$, $p < .001$, $\eta^2 = .05$). Providing support for H_{1a}, planned comparisons revealed that participants reported significantly higher intentions to spread positive WOM in the returnless return condition ($M = 5.91$, $SD = 1.44$) than in the control condition ($M = 5.29$, $SD = .99$; $t(299) = 3.40$, $p < .001$, $d = .50$). Supporting H_{1b}, participants also reported significantly higher intentions to spread positive WOM in the returnless condition than in the standard return condition ($M = 5.23$, $SD = 1.40$; $t(299) = 3.70$, $p < .001$, $d = .47$). Consistent with Study 2, we find no significant differences between the control and standard return conditions ($t(299) = .29$, $p = .77$, $d = .04$).

Mediation. To test whether increased brand support due to returnless returns is driven by perceptions of brand warmth and not perceptions of competence or the financial value received during the interaction with the brand, we conducted a bootstrapped parallel mediation analysis (Mediation Model 4; multicategorical independent variable (IV) coded as returnless = 0, control = 1, standard return = 2; Hayes 2018). The first contrast assesses the effect of experiencing a returnless return versus experiencing a control situation in which the product did not need to be returned. As predicted, this analysis revealed significant mediation, such that a returnless product return (vs. control) increased brand warmth, which in turn led to greater intentions to spread positive WOM (95% CI = [−.85, −.43]; see Web Appendix D for figures illustrating the results from tests of mediation). However, we did not find significant indirect effects through brand competence (95% CI = [−.14, .11]) or perceived value (95% CI = [−.12, .11]).[5] The second contrast assesses the effect of experiencing a returnless return versus a standard product return. Again, as predicted, this analysis revealed significant mediation, such that a returnless return (vs. standard return) increased brand warmth, which in turn led to greater positive WOM (95% CI = [−.47, −.15]); also as before, neither perceived value (95% CI = [−.10, .17])

[5] See Table 1 for means across conditions for brand warmth and alternative mechanisms in this and all other studies.

nor competence (95% CI = [−.03, .04]) significantly mediated the effect.

Study 3b: Method

A total of 201 individuals (M_{age} = 39.6 years; 51.7% female, 47.3% male, 1.0% other) located in the United States and recruited from CloudResearch Connect participated in Study 3b. The study had two conditions: standard return and returnless return. All participants imagined that they purchased antidiarrheal medication from an online retail brand, but upon receiving the bottle, they found that it was completely empty. As in prior studies, participants were told that they contacted the brand to let them know about the situation and were either asked to return the product by putting it in its original packaging and leaving it at their door for pickup (standard return) or informed that they did not need to return the item (returnless return).

After reading the brand's response, participants responded to the same measures assessing intentions to spread positive WOM (α = .98) and perceived warmth (α = .97) as in Study 3a. Participants also responded to items adapted from Gershon and Cryder (2018) to assess the brand's perceived communal orientation ("The brand has a genuine desire to help others," "The brand helped to respond to others' needs," and "The brand did not expect to receive any benefits from helping"; 1 = not at all; 7 = very much; α = .93), items adapted from Olson et al. (2016) to assess perceived brand morality ("This brand is …" [1 = "immoral," and 7 = "moral"; 1 = "unethical," and 7 = "ethical"]; r = .93), items adapted from Warren and Campbell (2014) to assess perceived brand coolness ("This brand is …" [1 = "not hip," and 7 = "hip"; 1 = "not cool," and 7 = "cool"]; r = .92), and an item adapted from Lau-Gesk (2005) to assess perceived novelty ("How novel was this experience?"; 1 = "not at all novel," and 7 = "very novel").

Study 3b: Results

Positive WOM. We first submitted our positive WOM measure to a one-way ANOVA with condition as the independent variable. Providing support for H_{1b}, participants differed in their intentions to spread positive WOM ($F(1, 199) = 20.55$, $p < .001$, $\eta^2 = .09$), such that participants reported significantly higher positive WOM intentions in the returnless return condition (M = 4.22, SD = 1.85) than the standard return condition (M = 3.04, SD = 1.84).

Mediation. To test our second key hypothesis (H_2) that increased brand support due to returnless returns is serially driven by perceptions of the brand's communal orientation and brand warmth and not perceptions of brand morality, brand coolness, or novelty, we conducted two bootstrapped mediation analyses. In the first, we entered perceived brand warmth, brand morality, brand coolness, and novelty as simultaneous parallel mediators (Mediation Model 4; coded as returnless = 0, standard return = 1; Hayes 2018). As predicted, this analysis revealed significant mediation, such that a returnless product return (vs. standard return) increased perceived brand warmth, which in turn led to greater intentions to spread positive WOM (95% CI = [−1.26, −.49]; see Web Appendix D for figures illustrating the results from tests of mediation). However, we did not find significant indirect effects through perceived brand morality (95% CI = [−.14, .03]), perceived brand coolness (95% CI = [−.14, .05]), or perceived novelty (95% CI = [−.03, .05]).

In the second mediation model, we entered perceptions of the brand's communal orientation and brand warmth to test serial mediation (Mediation Model 6; Hayes 2018). As predicted in H_2, this analysis revealed significant mediation, such that a returnless return (vs. standard return) increased perceptions of the brand's communal orientation, which increased perceived brand warmth, which in turn led to greater intentions to spread positive WOM (95% CI = [−.60, −.13]).

Studies 3a and 3b: Discussion

Studies 3a and 3b demonstrate support for H_2. The boost in brand support caused by using returnless returns (vs. standard returns and vs. control) is mediated by greater perceptions of the brand's communal orientation, which in turn increases perceived brand warmth. We do not find evidence that the effect is driven by greater perceived value or perceived competence (Study 3a), nor is it driven by brand morality, coolness, or novelty of the experience (Study 3b).

Study 4: Requiring Proof Attenuates the Positive Effects of Offering Returnless Returns

Having documented the effect of using returnless returns on brand support in addition to the mechanism driving this effect, we turn our attention to leveraging our theoretical framework to identify moderators of this effect. We first explore whether the brand requires proof of a product issue when offering a returnless return. We expect that doing so will attenuate the positive effect of returnless returns on brand support (specifically, positive WOM) because consumers will not be as likely to view offering a returnless return as a signal of the mutual trust and kindness that is expected in communal relationships (H_3).

Method

A total of 302 individuals (M_{age} = 44.9 years; 48.7% female, 49.7% male, 1.7% other) located in the United States, Canada, or the United Kingdom and recruited from CloudResearch Connect participated in the study. All participants were randomly assigned to one of three conditions: standard return, returnless return, or returnless return (proof required). Participants read that they ordered a phone charger online, but that upon receiving the phone charger they found

that it did not work when plugged into an outlet. As in prior studies, in the standard condition, the brand promised to issue a refund and asked the participant to return the charger in question. In the returnless condition, the brand's response was the exact same except that it informed participants that there was no need to return the charger in question. In the returnless (proof required) condition, the brand's response was the same as the returnless condition except that it further informed participants of a need to provide proof of the defect (via photograph or video) on the company's website. After reading the brand's response, participants reported their intentions to spread positive WOM ($\alpha = .98$) and perceived brand warmth ($\alpha = .96$) as in Studies 3a–b.

Results

Positive WOM. We submitted our positive WOM measure to a one-way omnibus ANOVA with condition as the independent variable. This analysis revealed an effect of condition ($F(2, 299) = 7.03$, $p = .001$, $\eta^2 = .04$). Supporting H_3, participants reported significantly higher intentions to spread positive WOM in the returnless return condition ($M = 4.35$, $SD = 1.72$) than the standard return condition ($M = 3.48$, $SD = 1.82$; $t(299) = 3.39$, $p < .001$, $d = .49$) and the returnless return (proof required) condition ($M = 3.57$, $SD = 1.88$; $t(299) = 3.08$, $p = .002$, $d = .43$). Consistent with our theorizing, the significant boost for returnless returns versus a standard return was eliminated when the brand asked the consumer to provide proof of the defect ($t(299) = .34$, $p = .733$, $d = .05$).

Mediation

To test whether this effect on positive WOM is driven by perceptions of brand warmth, we conducted two bootstrapped parallel mediation analyses. In the first (Mediation Model 4; Hayes 2018), we coded our multicategorical IV as returnless = 0, standard return = 1, and returnless (proof required) = 2. This analysis revealed two significant mediations: (1) replicating results from prior studies, a returnless return (vs. standard return) increased perceived brand warmth, which in turn led to greater intentions to spread positive WOM (95% CI = [−1.29, −.55]), and (2) a returnless return (vs. returnless return requiring proof) increased perceived brand warmth, which in turn led to greater intentions to spread positive WOM (95% CI = [−1.19, −.42]). In the second mediation analysis (Mediation Model 4; Hayes 2018), we coded our multicategorical IV as standard return = 0, returnless = 1, and returnless (proof required) = 2 to compare the effect of offering returnless returns when simultaneously asking for proof to offering standard returns. Consistent with our theorizing, this analysis revealed no significant mediation for this contrast (95% CI = [−.26, .53]); requiring proof attenuated the positive effect of returnless returns (vs. standard returns) on brand support because it did not boost perceived warmth ($t(299) = .65$, $p = .514$, $d = .09$).

Discussion

Study 4 demonstrates support for H_3, such that requiring proof (e.g., a photograph of the item) attenuates the positive effect of returnless returns on brand support because consumers will not be as likely to view offering a returnless return as a signal of the mutual trust expected in communal relationships and thus will not view the brand as warmer. In Studies 5–7, we continue leveraging our theoretical framework to identify practical moderators of the effect of using returnless returns on brand support, focusing on how the brand designs its returnless return policy and communicates its decision-making process around product returns to consumers.

Study 5: Returnless Product Returns Are More Effective When They Are Communicated as Case Specific (vs. as a Blanket Policy)

In Study 5, we test whether the boost in brand support differs depending on whether the brand designs the returnless product return policy to be implemented on a case-by-case basis or as a blanket policy (H_4). We expect that the positive effect of offering returnless product returns on brand support (specifically, repurchase intentions) will manifest in both cases but will be stronger when the brand communicates that the decision was made on a case-by-case basis involving human intervention rather than as part of a blanket policy, as the former communication further boosts perceived warmth.

Method

A total of 600 individuals ($M_{age} = 38.2$ years; 45.8% female, 53.2% male, 1.0% other) located in the United States and recruited from CloudResearch Connect participated in the study. All participants were randomly assigned to one of four conditions in a 2 (return type: standard vs. returnless) × 2 (decision type: policy vs. case-by-case) between-subjects design. All participants read that they purchased some fruit and vegetables from an online retailer, but that the quality of the food that they received was not what they expected. We next manipulated the brand's response to be either a standard return (where they were directed to put the fruit and vegetables in their original packaging so that the seller could pick them up from their door) or a returnless return (where there was no need to return the fruit and vegetables). We crossed this return type manipulation with our key manipulation in Study 5: decision type. Whereas half of the participants were informed that the decision was based on company policy, the other half were informed that this decision was made by someone who had reviewed their case and history as a customer.

After reading the brand's response, participants first reported how likely they would be to consider purchasing from the brand again (measure adapted from Zeithaml, Berry, and Parasuraman [1996]). Responses were made on a 1–7 scale, scored such that higher values reflected a greater likelihood of repurchasing.

Participants closed the study by responding to the same three measures assessing perceived brand warmth used in prior studies ($\alpha = .96$).

Results

Repurchase intentions. We submitted our repurchase intentions measure to a two-way ANOVA with return type and decision type as the independent variables to test H_4. This analysis revealed a main effect of return type ($F(1, 596) = 288.67$, $p < .001$, $\eta_p^2 = .33$) and a marginally significant effect of decision type ($F(1, 596) = 3.32$, $p = .069$, $\eta_p^2 = .006$). More importantly, and as predicted, this analysis revealed a significant return type × decision type interaction ($F(1, 596) = 9.96$, $p = .002$, $\eta_p^2 = .02$; Figure 2), indicating that the effect of offering returnless returns on repurchase intentions differed when the brand communicated that the decision was made on a case-by-case basis versus when the decision was made as part of a blanket policy. Participants who were informed that the decision was made as part of a blanket policy reported significantly higher repurchase intentions when experiencing a returnless return ($M = 4.93$, $SD = 1.92$) than when experiencing a situation in which the product did not need to be returned ($M = 3.00$, $SD = 1.67$; $F(1, 596) = 95.15$, $p < .001$, $\eta_p^2 = .14$). However, the positive effect of experiencing a returnless return on repurchase intentions was much larger for participants who were informed that the decision was made on a case-by-case basis ($M_{returnless} = 5.63$, $SD = 1.61$; $M_{standard} = 2.81$, $SD = 1.64$; $F(1, 596) = 203.27$, $p < .001$, $\eta_p^2 = .25$), consistent with H_4. Analyzed differently, whereas participants who experienced a standard return did not significantly differ in their repurchase intentions by decision type ($F(1, 596) = .89$, $p = .346$, $\eta_p^2 = .001$), participants who were informed that the decision to implement a returnless return was made on a case-by-case basis reported significantly higher repurchase intentions than participants who were informed that the decision to implement a returnless return was made as part of a blanket policy ($F(1, 596) = 12.39$, $p < .001$, $\eta_p^2 = .02$).

Moderated mediation. To test whether perceived brand warmth explains why the positive effect of offering returnless product returns on repurchase intentions is stronger when the brand communicates that the decision is made on a case-by-case basis rather than as part of a blanket policy, we conducted a bootstrapped moderated mediation analysis (Mediation Model 7; Hayes 2018). As predicted, this analysis revealed significant moderated mediation (index of moderated mediation 95% CI: [.19, .98]), such that the indirect effect of returnless returns (vs. standard returns) on repurchase intentions through increased perceived brand warmth was significantly stronger when the decision is made on a case-by-case basis than as a blanket policy.[6]

[6] A similar bootstrapped moderated mediation analysis using Model 8 (where the mediator simultaneously moderates the "a" link and direct effect) also revealed significant moderated mediation (index of moderated mediation 95% CI: [.20, .93]).

Discussion

Study 5 shows support for H_4—the positive effect of offering returnless product returns on brand support is stronger when the brand communicates that the decision was made on a case-by-case basis rather than as part of a blanket policy. We also find significant moderated mediation evidence through perceived brand warmth and show the robustness of the effect using another operationalization of brand support: repurchase intentions.

Study 6: Returnless Product Returns Are More Effective When Implemented for Consumer-Centric or Environmentally-Centric Motives Than Company-Centric Motives

Study 6 (preregistration: https://aspredicted.org/cbxr-2j72.pdf) had two primary goals. First, we aimed to show that the boosts to brand support from offering returnless returns are consistent across the two primary dependent measures of brand support used in prior studies (intentions to spread positive WOM and repurchase intentions). Second, we aimed to test how the communication of the motivation for returnless returns might affect perceived warmth and brand support. Specifically, we predict that communicating consumer- and environmentally-centric motives will increase brand warmth and thus support relative to a company-centric approach (H_5) because showing kindness and generosity via taking steps to make consumers' lives easier is characteristic of warm brands (Aaker, Vohs, and Mogilner 2010; Kervyn, Fiske, and Malone 2012), and sustainable brands are viewed as warmer (Antonetti and Maklan 2016; Septianto, Seo, and Zhao 2022).

Method

A total of 801 individuals ($M_{age} = 40.9$ years; 46.4% female, 51.7% male, 1.9% other) located in the United States and recruited from CloudResearch Connect participated in the study. Participants were randomly assigned to one of four conditions (returnless consumer-centric vs. returnless environmentally-centric vs. returnless company-centric vs. standard return). All participants read a similar scenario to that in Study 5, in which they purchased some fruit and vegetables from an online retailer, but that the quality of the food that they received was not what they expected. We next manipulated the brand's response after the customer informed the brand of the situation. Similar to Study 5, participants assigned to the standard return condition were directed to put the fruit in its original packaging so that it could be picked up from their door. The three new key conditions were the returnless consumer-centric, the returnless environmentally-centric, and the returnless company-centric conditions. In each, participants were informed that there was no need to return the fruit. However, in the first condition, participants were told that the reason for using returnless returns

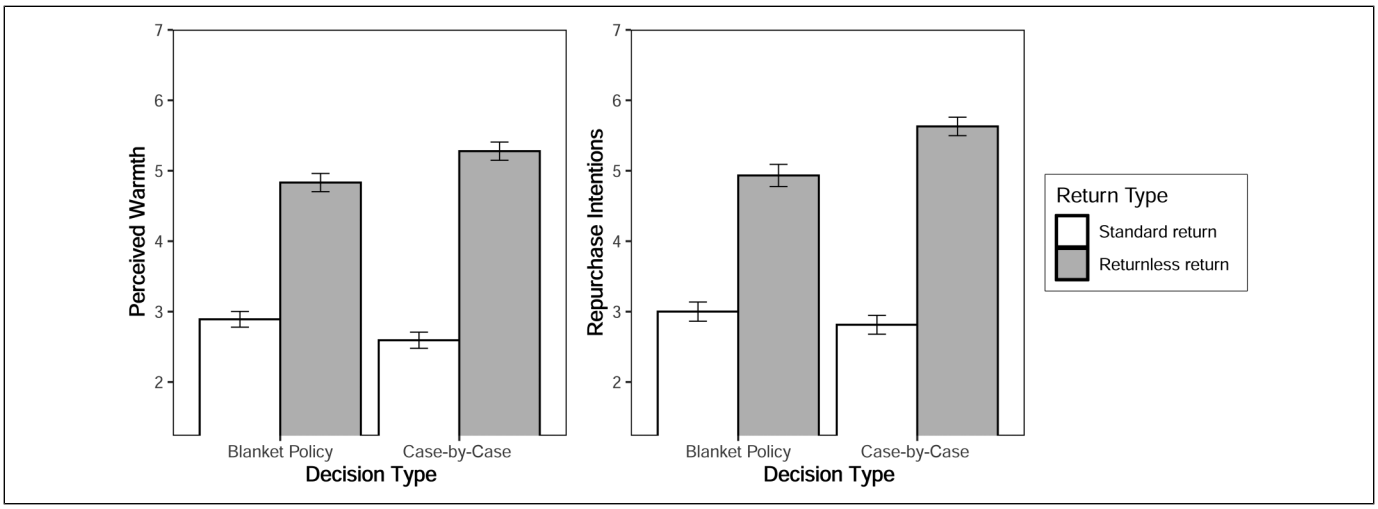


Figure 2. Perceived Warmth and Repurchase Intentions by Return Type and Decision Type in Study 5.

was to make customers' lives better; in the second, participants were told that the reason was to promote sustainability and avoid unnecessary carbon emissions; and in the last, participants were told that the reason was to reduce costs. After reading the brand's response, participants reported their intentions to spread positive WOM ($\alpha = .98$), how likely they would be to repurchase from the brand ("Based on this response, how likely would you be to purchase from this brand again?"; 1 = "very unlikely," and 7 = "very likely") and answered the same three measures assessing perceived brand warmth used in prior studies ($\alpha = .97$).

Results

Brand support. We first conducted two one-way ANOVAs, one with positive WOM as the dependent variable and the other with repurchase intentions as the dependent variable. Both analyses used condition as the independent variable. As predicted, this analysis revealed that intentions to spread positive WOM ($F(3, 797) = 72.07$, $p < .001$, $\eta^2 = .21$) and repurchase intentions ($F(3, 797) = 60.03$, $p < .001$, $\eta^2 = .18$; see Figure 3) differed by condition. Replicating prior studies and providing further support for H_1, participants experiencing a returnless return reported significantly lower intentions to spread positive WOM when experiencing a standard product return ($M = 3.20$, $SD = 1.56$) than when experiencing returnless returns that the brand communicated as having consumer-centric motives ($M = 5.31$, $SD = 1.50$; $t(797) = 13.27$, $p < .001$, $d = 1.37$), communicated as for environmentally-centric motives, ($M = 5.11$, $SD = 1.60$; $t(797) = 12.02$, $p < .001$, $d = 1.21$), or communicated as for company-centric motives ($M = 4.69$, $SD = 1.68$; $t(797) = 9.43$, $p < .001$, $d = .92$). Similarly, participants' repurchase intentions were lower with a standard product return ($M = 3.44$, $SD = 1.76$) than with returnless returns that the brand communicated as being for consumer-centric motives ($M = 5.48$, $SD = 1.52$; $t(797) = 12.10$, $p < .001$, $d = 1.24$), environmentally-centric motives, ($M = 5.30$, $SD = 1.65$; $t(797) = 11.06$, $p < .001$, $d = 1.10$), or company-centric motives ($M = 4.82$, $SD = 1.80$; $t(797) = 8.20$, $p < .001$, $d = .77$).

Of primary importance, supporting H_5, participants who experienced a returnless return reported significantly higher intentions to spread positive WOM when the brand communicated that the decision was made for consumer-centric motives or environmentally-centric motives compared with when the decision was made for company-centric motives ($t(797) = 3.86$, $p < .001$, $d = .38$ and $t(797) = 2.61$, $p = .009$, $d = .25$, respectively). A parallel pattern of results was observed for repurchase intentions, such that the likelihood of repurchase was higher when the brand communicated consumer-centric motives or environmentally-centric motives rather than company-centric motives ($t(797) = 3.91$, $p < .001$, $d = .40$ and $t(797) = 2.87$, $p = .004$, $d = .28$, respectively). Participants reported similar levels of brand support when the brand communicated that the decision was made for consumer-centric motives as when the brand communicated that the decision was made for environmentally-centric motives (WOM: $t(797) = 1.25$, $p = .212$, $d = .13$; repurchase: ($t(797) = 1.04$, $p = .300$, $d = .11$).).

Mediation. To test whether perceived brand warmth explains the observed differences in intentions to spread positive WOM and repurchase, we conducted two bootstrapped parallel mediation analyses for each dependent variable. In the first set of mediation analyses (Mediation Model 4; Hayes 2018), we coded our multicategorical IV as standard return = 0, returnless consumer-centric = 1, returnless environmentally-centric = 2, and returnless company-centric = 3. As predicted and consistent with H_1 and H_2, this analysis revealed significant mediation for each of the three contrasts for both dependent variables. Compared with standard returns, returnless product returns increased perceived brand warmth, which in turn led to greater intentions to spread positive WOM when the brand

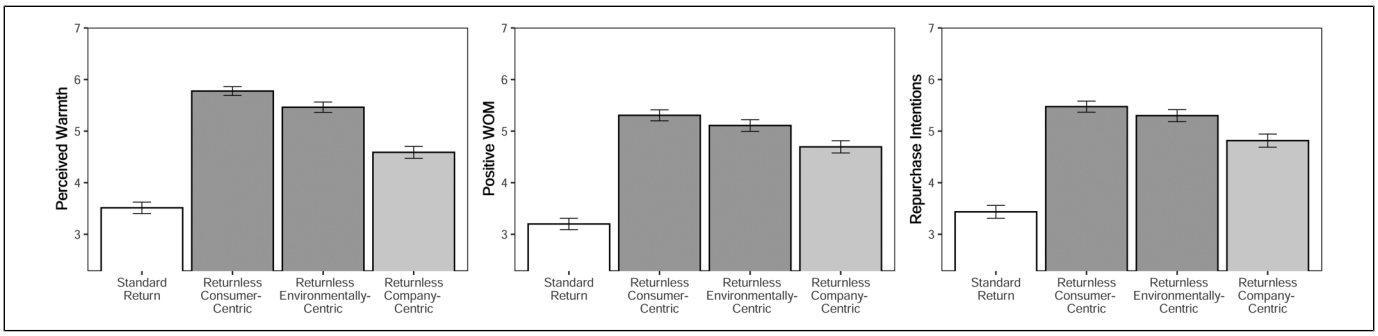


Figure 3. Perceived Warmth, Positive WOM, and Repurchase Intentions by Condition in Study 6.

communicated consumer-centric (95% CI = [1.44, 1.89]), environmentally-centric (95% CI = [1.22, 1.66]), or company-centric motives (95% CI = [.57, 1.02]). Further, compared with standard returns, returnless product returns increased perceived brand warmth, which in turn led to greater repurchase intentions when the brand communicated consumer-centric (95% CI = [1.51, 1.99]), environmentally-centric (95% CI = [1.26, 1.76]), or company-centric motives (95% CI = [.59, 1.08]).

Our second set of mediation analyses directly test H_5 (Mediation Model 4; multicategorical IV coded as returnless company-centric = 0, returnless consumer-centric = 1, returnless environmentally-centric = 2, and standard return = 3; Hayes 2018). Supporting H_5, this analysis revealed significant mediation for each of the two new contrasts for both dependent variables. Compared with communicating company-centric motives when offering returnless product returns, communicating consumer-centric or environmentally-centric motives boosted perceived warmth, which in turn led to greater intentions to spread positive WOM (95% CI = [.66, 1.09] and 95% CI = [.41, .87], respectively). Further, compared with communicating company-centric motives when offering returnless product returns, communicating consumer-centric or environmentally-centric motives boosted perceived warmth, which in turn led to greater repurchase intentions (95% CI = [.69, 1.14] and 95% CI = [.44, .91], respectively).

Discussion

Study 6 replicates our prior results, as using returnless returns (vs. standard returns) increases brand warmth and thus brand support (measured as both repurchase intentions and intentions to spread positive WOM). More importantly, Study 6 demonstrates support for H_5—communicating a consumer- or environmentally-centric motivation increases brand warmth and support versus a company-centric motive. This suggests that brands must be mindful when communicating why they are implementing a returnless return. To assess the robustness of this result, we conducted a replication of Study 6 (Supplemental Study 1) in which we solely measured the effect of these suggestions on repurchase intentions. We again observed that communicating a consumer- or environmentally-centric motivation increases brand warmth and support versus a company-centric motive (Web Appendix E).

Study 7: Returnless Product Returns Are More Effective at Increasing Brand Support When Brands Suggest That the Customer Donate the Kept Item

Study 7 (preregistration: https://aspredicted.org/j8zy-37qp.pdf) explores another common feature in returnless product return communications related to product disposition suggestions. We posit that communicating a suggestion about what to do with the kept product offers the brand an additional opportunity to signal warmth, which could further boost support. Drawing from donations research that shows a link between giving behaviors and warmth perceptions (Gershon and Cryder 2018; Kervyn, Fiske, and Malone 2022), we propose that suggesting that consumers donate the kept item will be particularly effective in bolstering perceptions of brand warmth and thus support (H_6).

Method

A total of 900 individuals (M_{age} = 41.5 years; 59.8% female, 40.0% male, .2% other) located in the United States and recruited from Prolific participated in the study. Participants were randomly assigned to one of three returnless return conditions (no suggestion vs. suggest donation vs. suggest disposal). All participants read a similar scenario to that experienced by participants in the returnless return conditions in Study 3a—specifically, they purchased a sweater from an online retailer, but it did not look flattering on them. Unlike prior studies, participants across all conditions experienced a returnless return. Our focal manipulation was whether the brand suggested what to do with the sweater and the nature of the suggestion. Whereas participants assigned to the no-suggestion condition did not see a suggestion for what to do with the sweater, participants assigned to the suggest-disposal condition were told to "Please consider disposing of it!," and participants assigned to the suggest-donation condition were told to "Please consider giving it to someone in need!" Participants then reported their intentions to spread positive WOM (α = .97), repurchase

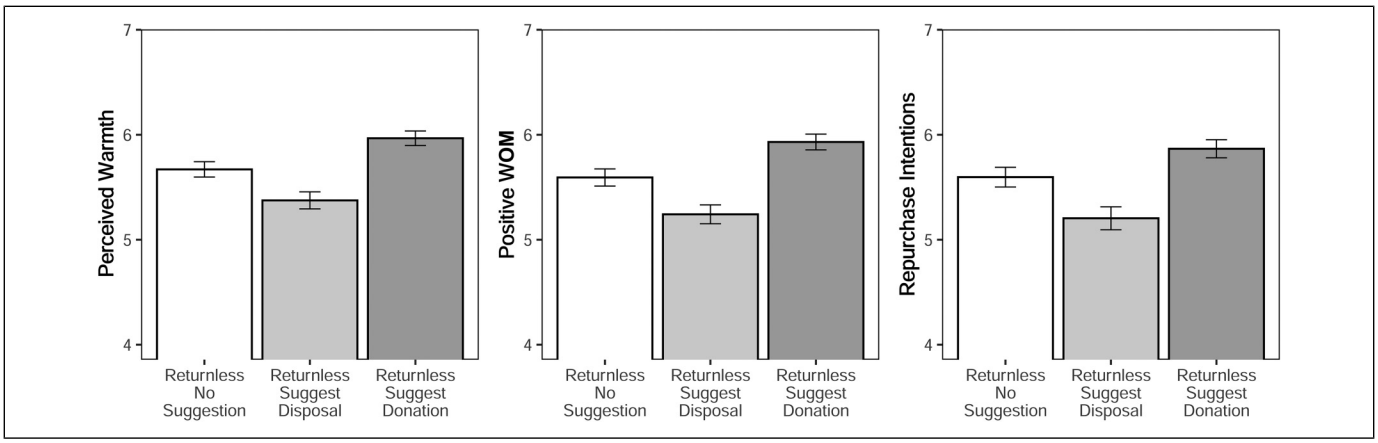


Figure 4. Perceived Warmth, Positive WOM, and Repurchase Intentions by Condition in Study 7.

intentions, and perceptions of the brand's warmth ($\alpha = .95$) as in Study 6.

Results

Brand support. As in Study 6, we first conducted two ANOVAs with condition as the independent variable and intentions to spread positive WOM and repurchase intentions as dependent variables. As predicted, this analysis revealed that intentions to spread positive WOM ($F(2, 897) = 17.43$, $p < .001$, $\eta^2 = .04$) and repurchase intentions ($F(2, 897) = 11.77$, $p < .001$, $\eta^2 = .03$) differed by condition (see Figure 4). Supporting H_6, participants who experienced a returnless return reported significantly higher intentions to spread positive WOM when the brand suggested that they donate the kept item ($M = 5.93$, $SD = 1.30$) compared with when no suggestion was given ($M = 5.59$, $SD = 1.42$; $t(897) = 2.91$, $p = .004$, $d = .25$) and when the brand suggested that they dispose of the kept item ($M = 5.24$, $SD = 1.55$; $t(897) = 5.90$, $p < .001$, $d = .48$). Similarly, and also supporting H_6, participants also reported higher repurchase intentions when the brand suggested that they donate the kept item ($M = 5.87$, $SD = 1.49$) compared with when no suggestion was given ($M = 5.60$, $SD = 1.63$; $t(897) = 1.97$, $p = .049$, $d = .17$) and when the brand suggested that they dispose of the kept item ($M = 5.20$, $SD = 1.89$; $t(897) = 4.83$, $p < .001$, $d = .39$). Notably, but not germane to H_6, participants also reported lower intentions to spread positive WOM in the suggest-disposal condition ($M = 5.59$, $SD = 1.42$) than the no-suggestion condition ($t(897) = -3.01$, $p = .003$, $d = -.24$) and lower repurchase intentions in the suggest-disposal condition ($M = 5.59$, $SD = 1.42$) than the no-suggestion condition ($t(897) = -2.86$, $p = .004$, $d = -.22$).

Mediation. We conducted mediation analyses to test whether perceived brand warmth explains the observed differences in intentions to spread positive WOM and repurchase intentions (Model 4; multicategorical IV coded as suggest donation = 0, no suggestion = 1, and suggest disposal = 2; Hayes 2018). The first contrast assessed the effect of suggesting that the customer donate the item versus providing no suggestion, while the second contrast assessed the effect of suggesting that the customer donate versus dispose of the item. Analyses revealed significant mediation for both contrasts on each dependent variable. First, suggesting donation increased brand warmth, which in turn led to greater intentions to spread positive WOM both when compared with providing no suggestion (95% CI = [−.41, −.08]) and suggesting disposal (95% CI = [−.66, −.31]). Second, suggesting donating the item increased brand warmth, which in turn led to greater repurchase intentions when compared with both providing no suggestion (95% CI = [−.43, −.09]) and suggesting disposal (95% CI = [−.71, −.32]).

Discussion

Study 7 showed support for H_6—when implementing returnless returns, suggesting that consumers donate the kept item can be particularly effective in bolstering perceptions of brand warmth and, thus, support (both for positive WOM and repurchase intentions). Two supplemental studies reported in Web Appendix E (Supplemental Studies 2 and 3) provide further support for this prediction.

General Discussion

A growing number of brands have rolled out what we call returnless returns, where consumers are told to keep the product they want to be replaced or refunded (Cerullo 2021; Kavilanz 2022; Repko 2022; Reuter 2024). Our work explores consumer response to returnless returns across nine experimental studies and is the first in the academic literature to investigate the topic of returnless returns more broadly. We find that consumers demonstrate greater brand support after experiencing a returnless return relative to consumers who experience a standard product return, as well as consumers who make purchases that are not returned. This effect holds across a variety of measures of brand support (e.g., repurchase intentions, text analysis

of written reviews, intentions to share positive WOM, preference for the brand vs. competitors, brand evaluation) and contextual variables (e.g., different product categories, more embarrassing and less embarrassing purchases, reasons for initiating the return). We further provide mediation evidence that increased perceptions of brand warmth drive the effect.

Importantly, we leverage our new theoretical framework to identify managerially relevant variables that impact the extent to which returnless returns increase brand warmth and support. Specifically, we find that returnless returns more effectively increase brand support when the brand does not require proof of a defective product, when the decision is framed as specific to that consumer and situation (vs. a blanket policy), when the brand provides a consumer- or environmentally-centric motive for the decision (vs. a company-centric motive), and when the brand suggests that the consumer donate the kept product (vs. no suggestion or suggests disposal). Thus, our findings provide practical guidance for how brands should design their return procedures and communicate with consumers during the return process.

Theoretical Contributions

Broadly speaking, our research contributes to the literature on postpurchase behavior—a literature that has examined behaviors such as product disposition, consumer response to conditional review requests, and customer complaints (Cakanlar, Nikolova, and Nenkov 2023; Dommer and Winterich 2021; Koukova, Wang, and Isaac 2023; Winterich, Nenkov, and Gonzales 2019). We shed light on consumers' psychological response to another important and increasingly prevalent touchpoint in the postpurchase step of the consumer journey: product returns. As the first article focusing on returnless returns, a key theoretical contribution of our work is building an initial understanding of how consumers respond to the practice and the impact of various strategies that brands might use during the return process. In doing so, we answer calls for more research testing the role of product return policies on consumer behavior (Abdulla, Ketzenberg, and Abbey 2019; Robertson, Hamilton, and Jap 2020). We encourage future research on consumers' reactions to returnless returns and how managers can best communicate and implement these policies, given the increasing frequency that (1) consumers are seeking to return their recent purchases and (2) firms are directing consumers to keep purchases they wish to return.

Our research builds on a rich literature that reveals how consumer–brand relationships (Aggarwal 2009; Aggarwal and Law 2005) and consumer inference-making (Summers, Smith, and Reczek 2016) can affect brand perceptions. Specifically, we document the role of return processes and communications in shaping perceptions of brand warmth (Fournier and Alvarez 2012; Kervyn, Fiske, and Malone 2012), thus identifying a new avenue through which brands can convey warmth beyond factors previously identified, such as brands' business models (Aaker, Vohs, and Mogilner 2010; Lee, Bolton, and Winterich 2017), corporate social responsibility initiatives (Gershon and Cryder 2018), use of emojis in service encounters (Li, Chan, and Kim 2019), and product development processes (Philipp-Muller, Costello, and Reczek 2023). While previous work has suggested that product returns policies can impact perceptions of brand competence (Guo et al. 2020), ours is the first in this literature to focus on the warmth dimension of the stereotype content model. We propose that this theoretical orientation is particularly valuable given the growing evidence for the "primacy of warmth" (Kervyn, Fiske, and Malone 2022; Wojciszke, Bazinska, and Jaworski 1998) in brand evaluations.

Practical Contributions

Our findings offer important insights for firms that are designing or updating their product return policies and that are interested in improving how they are viewed by customers who seek to return purchases. Broadly, our research offers general recommendations about the potential benefits of returnless returns on brand support (in terms of positive WOM, repurchase likelihood, likelihood to prefer the brand over competitors, etc.), identifies when returnless returns are most effective in driving support, and provides guidelines for how brands should communicate with customers during the return process (Figure 5).

First, from a general perspective, our research suggests that firms should not overlook the positives of returnless returns on brand support. While this recommendation might seem intuitive to some, it contradicts narratives in the popular press (e.g., Cerullo 2021; Kavilanz 2022; Repko 2022; Reuter 2024) and data from our pilot study with retail professionals that both indicate that cost is the primary consideration when firms make decisions about returnless returns. Second, our research identifies when returnless returns are most effective in boosting brand support (Studies 4 and 5). Third, our research provides insights into how brands should communicate with consumers during the return process. For instance, articulating a consumer-centric motive for offering returnless returns and suggesting that consumers donate the kept product further boost perceived brand warmth and support (Studies 6 and 7, respectively).

Limitations and Future Research

Of course, given the variance in the value of items, it is not sensible for every firm to use returnless returns in every situation. Our recommendation that managers consider implementing these policies to boost brand support is limited to situations in which the costs of doing so are practically feasible (e.g., for firms selling lower-ticket items). That said, we expect the boost to brand support to persist in contexts where firms are also selling high-cost items.[7] Further, while we demonstrate that our effect emerges across various motives for making a return (e.g., when the return occurs due to both a consumer

[7] During the course of writing, revising, and presenting this research, we have heard stories from fellow academics who were directed to keep expensive products including TVs, weight racks, and hundreds of dollars of underwear.

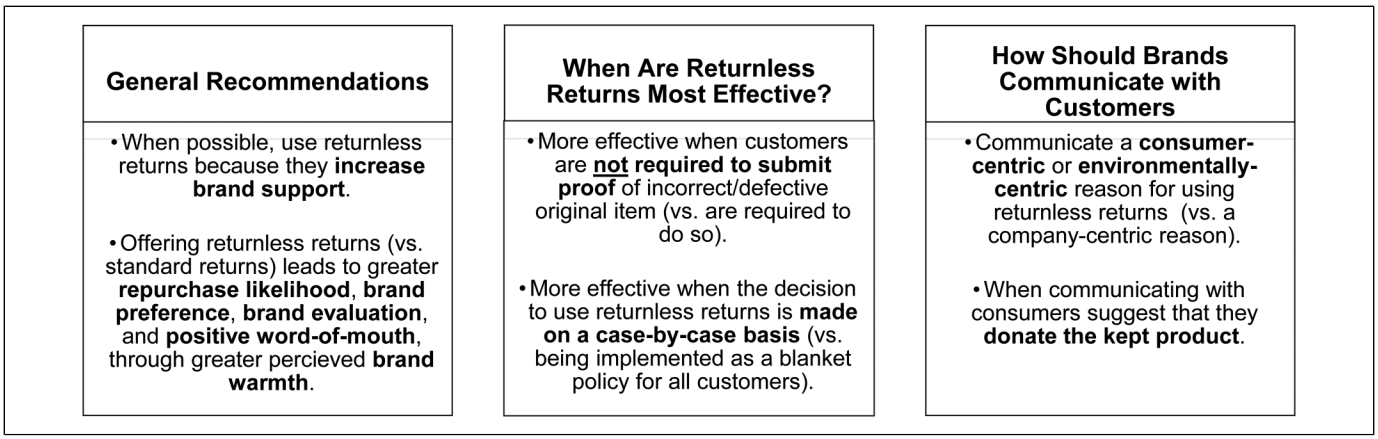


Figure 5. Recommendations and Insights for Managers.

mistake and a company mistake), future research might profitably explore how the reason for returning impacts perceived warmth and, thus, brand support. Our empirical package is also limited in that we do not consider potentially fraudulent customers. Replacement fraud seems to be growing in prevalence (Baertlein and McLymore 2023) and is another reason why implementing returnless returns on a case-by-case basis might be preferable to implementing returnless returns as a blanket policy. We encourage future research to explore how brands using returnless returns might mitigate fraud without diminishing perceptions of warmth and brand support.

Finally, future work might also systematically assess the environmental benefits and costs accompanying returnless returns. On the one hand, returnless returns could result in more waste because more products are disposed of and fewer are repaired and resold (see Hong, Dommer, and Winterich [2021] for an example of how firms' return programs can boost sustainability). On the other hand, in some cases, returnless returns are used because they reduce carbon footprints (Cerullo 2021)—a positive outcome that should not be overlooked, given the rising environmental costs of returning products to brands. We encourage future research on this important topic, given the ever-increasing frequency in which consumers seek to return their purchases.

Acknowledgments

The authors would like to thank Rebecca Walker Reczek for her comments on this research and the *JMR* review team for their exceptional guidance and feedback on this work.

Authors Contributions

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Declaration of Conflicting Interests

The author(s) declared no potential conflicts of interest with respect to the research, authorship, and/or publication of this article.

Funding

The author(s) received no financial support for the research, authorship, and/or publication of this article.

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